had crossed the Sikkim-Tibet border and built fortifications on the other side. This was not a new claim, but the timing was no coincidence and, if India would not comply with the request within three days, China would take action. The note did not say exactly what would happen after those three days, but it was a provocation India could not ignore. China made it clear that it would 'strengthen its defences and heighten its alertness along the border' and that a chain of consequences would follow due to the 'criminal and extended aggression by the Government of India'.[27]

The objective was clear, as China openly linked its actions on the Sikkimese border to the ongoing war between India and Pakistan. China's Foreign Minister Chen Yi, on a visit to Karachi on 4 September, had declared its support for the 'just struggle of the Kashmiri people' who were resisting 'India's tyrannical rule'.[28] China was on Pakistan's side because it had only acted in self-defence against Indian aggression, the minister suggested.

China was forced to extend its three-day ultimatum when the UN intervened and Secretary General U Thant held meetings with Pakistan's President Ayub Khan and the Indian Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri. Ayub Khan could not afford to let the war continue, as his forces were being crushed. China then issued a new note on 19 September, declaring its 'willingness' to put off the time limit to before the midnight of 22 September. The note also stated that the Chinese government 'gives all out support to the people of Kashmir in their struggle for the right of self-determination…and to Pakistan in her just struggle against Indian aggression'.[29]

On 20 September, a PLA unit moved into position at the Dongchui La pass and opened fire on the Indian soldiers there. The following day, another PLA unit began firing at Indian positions at Nathu La. But it was too late for China to launch a new war against India. The UN Security Council passed a resolution demanding that India and Pakistan cease hostilities and withdraw all their soldiers back to the positions they had held before 5 August. This was accepted by India as well as Pakistan, leaving China in limbo. A late response from Beijing came in the shape of a bizarre note claiming that India has withdrawn the intruding troops within the specified time limit set by the Chinese government, and had 'dismantled these military works of aggression'. But since then, the note